

who have common names and cannot go with a normal one, place some symbols between your first and last names. This may help differentiate you from others.

Ensure that your privacy settings are top notch. By doing this, you have the control of all the information that is being posted on your profile. Approve friend requests, links and tags beforehand and be careful of whom you choose to add as friend. Delete friends who you no longer keep in touch with.

It usually is a good practice to type in the name of the social networking site. Or, add a bookmark in your browser. The new scams on social media are done by emails that are similar to that of the social media provider. When you get such mails, assume the opposite – that it is a hoax.

Social media is a double edged sword and has to be used carefully. Never give out your travel plans on social media forums. This is the point where cybercriminals translate into real time threat, landing up at your home while you are not in town and burgling it. Never post about your whereabouts and especially, your residential address.

Most applications now have sign in options with social media. Never do that. This is just a great way to get access to your personal information on your profile. Else, read the terms and conditions carefully before you sign up. Otherwise, you don't know where your sensitive information may end up. Sadly, most company sell such databases of contact to businesses or private institutions, who are more often than not, up to no good. Exercise caution while you use the social networking sites. Not being cautious can mean that even your friends may lose their personal information in a bid to retrieve yours.

Your online reputation matters

Use extreme caution when opening links on social media sites. Even your friends can have their identities stolen on social media sites and post links that lead thieves to retrieve your personal information or hack your computer.

If you have children, lay down the ground rules of social media with them. Though youngsters may be more capable of making the most of social media, they might not understand its widespread ramifications, until it's too late.

Manage your online reputation. Start off with setting up a Google Alert for your name and also for those of your family. You can do this with your Gmail account, by clicking on the “More” tab on the Google toolbar. This option searches for your name on the internet and keeps you updated when any information with your name in it is used on the internet.